Twins are birds #3

Why is Reaching Thinking?

Why do people pay to sit in silence?

THE PROBLEM

Why do people pay to sit in silence?

Listening rooms originated in post war Japan before reaching the UK in the 2010s. *Spiritland* opened in 2016 as the first 'pure' listening bar, but *Brilliant Corners* - a Japanese restaurant in Dalston that sells a *salmon tartare and tobico* for £12 - is considered by people in Dalston as the pioneer.

Dalston + Japan + vinyl = The slow heat death of the slightly aging master codes for '*on trend*' into a red-faced-fist of curb chains, fixie bikes and tiny moustaches. Dozens of listening rooms now exist - bursting outwards from that single *Outré Sick* moment into a coronal mass ejection of valve amplification, rotary mixers and moving coil cartridges.

But are listening rooms trendy because they are trendy because they combine other trends? Or is that the ouroboros of piss poor cultural theory coming to bite on its own *buttocks*?

Why do people pay to sit in silence, listening to music they could get for free, on speakers they can neither afford nor understand the benefit of?

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Why is reaching thinking?

"The deficiency would appear, in the last resort, to affect a function much deeper than vision, deeper too than touch." - Merleau Ponty, 1945

Schneider had a headache. A fragment of shrapnel had lodged itself into the back of his head - right in the region of the brain where vision and spatial processing meet.

He could still see but the shapes no longer meant anything to him. He could still feel, but he didn't know where on his body the feeling was coming from.

His sensory relationship to the world was garbled and with it his ability for abstract reasoning.

Schneider knew where his nose was but when the doctors asked him to touch it he could not.

Then a mosquito landed there - and Schneider swatted it.

Did Schneider's body have a mind of its own?

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"For the normal person his projects polarize the world, bringing magically to view a host of signs which guide action, as notices in a museum guide the visitor."
- Merleau Ponty, 1945

Schneider could swat but not touch. Not because of a preference for insects over the medical profession, but because of the difference that comes from an abstract request and a concrete demand.

The swat was concrete - Something his body held within itself that became a response to the world in the moment of swatting.

The request was abstract - Something his mind needed to conjure - a projection into the world of the future possibility of touching.

But projection required abstraction - the thing Schneider had lost.

The point is that Schneider had half a WW1 British bomb in the back of his head. Most of the rest of us don't. So what does it mean for us?

Why is reaching thinking?

"I am not in space and time, nor do I conceive space and time; I belong to them, my body combines with them and includes them." - Merleau Ponty, 1945

Through Schneider and his bomb we learn something vital - we are not just abstract minds bobbling about somewhere in our skulls.

The world makes sense not because your mind processes it but because your body is in it.

Before anything else there is a body in a space. Because the body is alive it is active - always in motion - always reaching for something - oriented toward an act - from which flows experience like sparks from a comet.

Our bodies are that comet and that comet is us - our thinking rides its coattails - reading the sparks it sends to make sense of the darkness in which we find ourselves.

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"Consciousness is not originally an 'I think that,' but rather an'I can.'"

- Merleau Ponty, 1945

Reaching is thinking

Our bodies reach for the world and the world pulls us towards it, signals that demand action - notifications, messages, alarms, mosquitos. All of it drawing the body into postures that are already a form of understanding.

That orientation is where we find ourselves when we express a preference or make a decision, already poised - already leaning in one direction or the other.

The thinking is happening in our bodies as well as our minds - not as two separate machines where one steers the other - but as one and the same thing.

A single unified intelligence of body and mind always already in the flesh and always already reaching for the world.

THE SOLUTION

Why do people pay to sit in silence?

Listening rooms are not merely a re-dressing of the semiotics of Dalston coded good taste. This isn't just about the lure of analogue vinyl and less screen time. 'People want immersive experiences' not only because of a language of cultural codes but because of a very physical thing that is happening to their bodies.

Where the world is overwhelmingly full of signals - the slapping of infinite mosquitos - our bodies are pulled to react but never to reach. We become as incapable of abstract thought as Schneider and we find there is a bomb in our heads after all.

The listening room is the defusing of the bomb through the singularity of a beat. It's not about the music - its about the muting of everything else. Through the muting we are not pulled - we reach - and the reaching is worth paying a premium for.

People are paying to get their bodies back.

AFTERWORD

Merleau-Ponty and exciting ideas about brains and bodies

First, a confession. I lifted the idea of our bodies as comets almost directly from *Phenomenology of Perception*:

"If I stand in front of my desk and lean on it with both hands, only my hands are stressed and the whole of my body trails behind them like the tail of a comet."

It is the beautiful writing like this that makes rest of it worthwhile. It took me all day to read one chapter but it's filled with little flashes like that which accumulate and build so that by the end of it you can feel yourself fizzing with the 'what the fuck-ness' of it all.

We've got so lost all up in our heads and wrapped up in our language that we've forgotten what we really are - just animals in bodies reaching for a world that is forever beyond our understanding.

I sat in my garden when I was done and the sun was shining and my cat was playing and my coffee was hot and that felt like a pretty good thought to be sitting with.

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Thanks for reading

Read some more

The Phenomenology of Perception - Maurice Merleau-Ponty, 1945

The World of Perception - Maurice Merleau-Ponty, 2004

A Phenomenology of Landscape - Chris Tilley, 1994

Listening and Voice: A Phenomenology of Sound - Don Ihde, 1976

Read more Twins are birds

https://jimmott-collab.github.io/twins-are-birds/